

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Crafts, Commerce & Urban Growth (200 BC-AD 250) - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

Production-specialisation chain

Causal sequence; each arrow is conditional, not automatic



Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / WORKBOOK INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

Crafts, Commerce & Urban Growth (200 BC-AD 250) - Solved Practice Workbook	3
BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION	3
24. Learning MCQ loop 1-8	3
25. Learning MCQ loop 9-16	5
01. Workbook method and PYQ ownership	8
03. Broad MCQs 1-8	8
04. Broad MCQs 9-16	10
05. Broad MCQs 17-24	13
06. Broad MCQs 25-32	15
07. Remedial MCQs 1-8	17
PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE	19
23. Verified PYQ audit and direct/adjacent ownership	19
26. Solved Mains practice - 10, 15 and 20 marks	20
02. Solved verified/routed Prelims PYQs	21
08. Solved 10-mark questions	22
09. Solved 15-mark questions	23
10. Solved 20-mark questions	24
FINAL CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES - PLACED LAST	25

Crafts, Commerce & Urban Growth (200 BC-AD 250) - Solved Practice Workbook

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

24. Learning MCQ loop 1-8

[ANALYSIS] Original questions use strict A -> B -> C -> D rotation. Each solution explains the tested distinction.

Core teaching / solved practice

MCQ 01 - Q1

Which statement best captures the relation between second urbanisation and c. 200 BCE-250 CE growth?

- A. Post-Mauryan growth intensified an older urban base but followed regionally different paths
- B. Only overseas trade created towns
- C. The Deccan copied one Ganga model unchanged
- D. Towns first appeared only after 200 BCE

Answer: A - The correct frame is continuity plus intensification, with regional variation.

MCQ 02 - Q2

Which evidence most directly supports specialised textile processing at Arikamedu and Uraiyur?

- A. Ring wells
- B. Brick-built dyeing vats
- C. Roman coins
- D. Royal prashastis

Answer: B - Dyeing vats are production installations; coins or ring wells are indirect.

MCQ 03 - Q3

A mould producing repeated objects most safely indicates:

- A. Hereditary caste closure
- B. State monopoly
- C. Batch production or standardisation
- D. Export to Rome

Answer: C - Moulds show repeatability, not ownership, labour status or destination.

MCQ 04 - Q4

Which is the strongest caution about occupational clustering in a village?

- A. It proves no specialisation
- B. It proves all workers were slaves
- C. It proves the settlement was a capital
- D. It does not by itself prove guild membership or hereditary closure

Answer: D - Residence pattern, corporate membership and social status are distinct questions.

MCQ 05 - Q5

The Ahichchhatra expression kumhakara seniya is linked with:

- A. A potters' guild
- B. A caravan tax
- C. A royal mint
- D. A monastic council

Answer: A - The seal is used as evidence for a potters' corporate body.

MCQ 06 - Q6

Why are Maharashtra guild deposits significant?

- A. They prove state ownership of guilds
- B. They show corporate bodies entrusted with recurring religious provision
- C. They establish uniform interest rates
- D. They prove universal banking

Answer: B - Deposits show trust and endowment roles, but not a full modern banking system.

MCQ 07 - Q7

The route Taxila-Mathura-Ujjain-Bharuch primarily illustrates:

- A. A single Roman military road
- B. A purely coastal route
- C. An inland corridor linking the north-west to a western port
- D. A Gupta pilgrimage circuit

Answer: C - It connects inland nodes to Bharuch; route lines remain schematic.

MCQ 08 - Q8

Which statement about caravans is least defensible?

- A. Sangam material mentions chattu
- B. They moved inland goods
- C. They could pool risk and transport
- D. One uniform empire-wide caravan organisation is fully documented

Answer: D - Evidence supports caravans, not a standard pan-Indian corporate form.

Must-know facts

- Q1 key D: The correct frame is continuity plus intensification, with regional variation.
- Q2 key D: Dyeing vats are production installations; coins or ring wells are indirect.
- Q3 key D: Moulds show repeatability, not ownership, labour status or destination.
- Q4 key D: Residence pattern, corporate membership and social status are distinct questions.
- Q5 key D: The seal is used as evidence for a potters' corporate body.
- Q6 key D: Deposits show trust and endowment roles, but not a full modern banking system.
- Q7 key D: It connects inland nodes to Bharuch; route lines remain schematic.
- Q8 key D: Evidence supports caravans, not a standard pan-Indian corporate form.

UPSC traps

- WRONG: Memorise the option letter.

CORRECT: Revise the evidence distinction and elimination logic.

Mains angle: Use errors to revisit the relevant teaching section.

Study link: Topic 19 learning session.

25. Learning MCQ loop 9-16

[ANALYSIS] Original questions use strict A -> B -> C -> D rotation. Each solution explains the tested distinction.

Core teaching / solved practice

MCQ 09 - Q9

A port-hinterland approach begins with:

- A. Agrarian and craft supply feeding the port
- B. Imported amphorae alone
- C. Foreign colonies
- D. Royal capitals only

Answer: A - Ports depended on production, transport and inland consumption.

MCQ 10 - Q10

Which is the safest statement about the monsoon and maritime trade?

- A. Monsoon sailing eliminated coastal trade
- B. Seasonal wind knowledge enabled direct crossings within long-evolving Indian Ocean expertise
- C. It began only after 300 CE
- D. A single foreign sailor taught India sea travel

Answer: B - Avoid the one-discoverer myth and preserve accumulated regional knowledge.

MCQ 11 - Q11

Pliny's complaint about bullion outflow is best used as:

- A. Proof of Roman rule in India
- B. Proof that only pepper was traded
- C. Evidence of Roman anxiety about luxury imports
- D. A precise trade-balance statistic

Answer: C - It is rhetorical evidence, not a quantified balance sheet.

MCQ 12 - Q12

Amphorae at an Indian site do NOT by themselves prove:

- A. Elite consumption possibilities
- B. Imported container circulation
- C. Mediterranean-linked contact
- D. A resident Roman colony

Answer: D - Material contact and resident ethnicity are separate claims.

MCQ 13 - Q13

Which pairing is correct?

- A. Ujjain - agate and carnelian bead work
- B. Tamralipti - north-western caravan capital
- C. Mathura - Malabar pepper port
- D. Taxila - Tamil pearl fishery

Answer: A - Ujjain was a route junction and bead-working centre.

MCQ 14 - Q14

Kushana coinage is especially associated with:

- A. Roman imperial portraits only
- B. Gold and abundant copper denominations
- C. Only lead issues
- D. No legends

Answer: B - Kushanas issued both high-value gold and low-denomination copper.

MCQ 15 - Q15

Why is gold coinage an incomplete measure of monetisation?

- A. Gold never circulated
- B. Coins were only ritual
- C. Everyday exchange could use lower denominations, kind or barter
- D. Gold is archaeologically invisible

Answer: C - Different transaction scales used different media.

MCQ 16 - Q16

Which conclusion from city coins is excessive?

- A. Cities had political-economic identities
- B. Coinage can reveal institutions
- C. Urban authorities could issue coins
- D. Every city had sovereign independence

Answer: D - Issuing authority does not automatically equal full sovereignty.

Must-know facts

- Q9 key D: Ports depended on production, transport and inland consumption.
- Q10 key D: Avoid the one-discoverer myth and preserve accumulated regional knowledge.
- Q11 key D: It is rhetorical evidence, not a quantified balance sheet.
- Q12 key D: Material contact and resident ethnicity are separate claims.
- Q13 key D: Ujjain was a route junction and bead-working centre.
- Q14 key D: Kushanas issued both high-value gold and low-denomination copper.
- Q15 key D: Different transaction scales used different media.
- Q16 key D: Issuing authority does not automatically equal full sovereignty.

UPSC traps

- WRONG: Memorise the option letter.

CORRECT: Revise the evidence distinction and elimination logic.

Mains angle: Use errors to revisit the relevant teaching section.

Study link: Topic 19 learning session.

01. Workbook method and PYQ ownership

[FACT] The workbook contains four locally routed Prelims PYQs, 32 broad original MCQs, eight remedials and six solved Mains questions.

Core teaching / solved practice

- [LIMIT] No directly owned Mains PYQ was located in the audited local ledgers.
- [FACT] Original MCQs rotate A-B-C-D strictly across the 32-question broad sequence and again across the eight-question remedial sequence.
- [LIMIT] Actual PYQ answer letters are preserved and are not altered to fit rotation.

Must-know facts

- 2020 keys inferred; 2025 key official locally; 2026 key provisional.

UPSC traps

- WRONG: Provisional or inferred means official.

CORRECT: Status labels remain visible.

Mains angle: Use explanations for elimination practice.

Study link: Local routing ledgers.

03. Broad MCQs 1-8

[ANALYSIS] Original questions use strict A -> B -> C -> D rotation. Each solution explains the tested distinction.

Core teaching / solved practice

MCQ 17 - Q1

Which statement best captures the relation between second urbanisation and c. 200 BCE-250 CE growth?

- A. Post-Mauryan growth intensified an older urban base but followed regionally different paths
- B. Towns first appeared only after 200 BCE
- C. Only overseas trade created towns
- D. The Deccan copied one Ganga model unchanged

Answer: A - The correct frame is continuity plus intensification, with regional variation.

MCQ 18 - Q2

Which evidence most directly supports specialised textile processing at Arikamedu and Uraiyur?

- A. Royal prashastis
- B. Brick-built dyeing vats
- C. Ring wells
- D. Roman coins

Answer: B - Dyeing vats are production installations; coins or ring wells are indirect.

MCQ 19 - Q3

A mould producing repeated objects most safely indicates:

- A. Export to Rome
- B. State monopoly
- C. Batch production or standardisation
- D. Hereditary caste closure

Answer: C - Moulds show repeatability, not ownership, labour status or destination.

MCQ 20 - Q4

Which is the strongest caution about occupational clustering in a village?

- A. It proves all workers were slaves
- B. It proves no specialisation
- C. It proves the settlement was a capital
- D. It does not by itself prove guild membership or hereditary closure

Answer: D - Residence pattern, corporate membership and social status are distinct questions.

MCQ 21 - Q5

The Ahichchhatra expression kumhakara seniya is linked with:

- A. A potters' guild
- B. A monastic council
- C. A caravan tax
- D. A royal mint

Answer: A - The seal is used as evidence for a potters' corporate body.

MCQ 22 - Q6

Why are Maharashtra guild deposits significant?

- A. They establish uniform interest rates
- B. They show corporate bodies entrusted with recurring religious provision
- C. They prove universal banking
- D. They prove state ownership of guilds

Answer: B - Deposits show trust and endowment roles, but not a full modern banking system.

MCQ 23 - Q7

The route Taxila-Mathura-Ujjain-Bharuch primarily illustrates:

- A. A single Roman military road
- B. A Gupta pilgrimage circuit
- C. An inland corridor linking the north-west to a western port
- D. A purely coastal route

Answer: C - It connects inland nodes to Bharuch; route lines remain schematic.

MCQ 24 - Q8

Which statement about caravans is least defensible?

- A. Sangam material mentions chattu
- B. They moved inland goods
- C. They could pool risk and transport
- D. One uniform empire-wide caravan organisation is fully documented

Answer: D - Evidence supports caravans, not a standard pan-Indian corporate form.

Must-know facts

- Q1 key D: The correct frame is continuity plus intensification, with regional variation.
- Q2 key D: Dyeing vats are production installations; coins or ring wells are indirect.
- Q3 key D: Moulds show repeatability, not ownership, labour status or destination.
- Q4 key D: Residence pattern, corporate membership and social status are distinct questions.
- Q5 key D: The seal is used as evidence for a potters' corporate body.
- Q6 key D: Deposits show trust and endowment roles, but not a full modern banking system.
- Q7 key D: It connects inland nodes to Bharuch; route lines remain schematic.
- Q8 key D: Evidence supports caravans, not a standard pan-Indian corporate form.

UPSC traps

- WRONG: Memorise the option letter.

CORRECT: Revise the evidence distinction and elimination logic.

Mains angle: Use errors to revisit the relevant teaching section.

Study link: Topic 19 learning session.

04. Broad MCQs 9-16

[ANALYSIS] Original questions use strict A -> B -> C -> D rotation. Each solution explains the tested distinction.

Core teaching / solved practice

MCQ 25 - Q9

A port-hinterland approach begins with:

- A. Agrarian and craft supply feeding the port
- B. Royal capitals only
- C. Foreign colonies
- D. Imported amphorae alone

Answer: A - Ports depended on production, transport and inland consumption.

MCQ 26 - Q10

Which is the safest statement about the monsoon and maritime trade?

- A. It began only after 300 CE
- B. Seasonal wind knowledge enabled direct crossings within long-evolving Indian Ocean expertise
- C. Monsoon sailing eliminated coastal trade
- D. A single foreign sailor taught India sea travel

Answer: B - Avoid the one-discoverer myth and preserve accumulated regional knowledge.

MCQ 27 - Q11

Pliny's complaint about bullion outflow is best used as:

- A. Proof of Roman rule in India
- B. Proof that only pepper was traded
- C. Evidence of Roman anxiety about luxury imports
- D. A precise trade-balance statistic

Answer: C - It is rhetorical evidence, not a quantified balance sheet.

MCQ 28 - Q12

Amphorae at an Indian site do NOT by themselves prove:

- A. Imported container circulation
- B. Elite consumption possibilities
- C. Mediterranean-linked contact
- D. A resident Roman colony

Answer: D - Material contact and resident ethnicity are separate claims.

MCQ 29 - Q13

Which pairing is correct?

- A. Ujjain - agate and carnelian bead work
- B. Tamralipti - north-western caravan capital
- C. Taxila - Tamil pearl fishery
- D. Mathura - Malabar pepper port

Answer: A - Ujjain was a route junction and bead-working centre.

MCQ 30 - Q14

Kushana coinage is especially associated with:

- A. No legends
- B. Gold and abundant copper denominations
- C. Roman imperial portraits only
- D. Only lead issues

Answer: B - Kushanas issued both high-value gold and low-denomination copper.

MCQ 31 - Q15

Why is gold coinage an incomplete measure of monetisation?

- A. Gold never circulated
- B. Gold is archaeologically invisible
- C. Everyday exchange could use lower denominations, kind or barter
- D. Coins were only ritual

Answer: C - Different transaction scales used different media.

MCQ 32 - Q16

Which conclusion from city coins is excessive?

- A. Cities had political-economic identities
- B. Urban authorities could issue coins
- C. Coinage can reveal institutions
- D. Every city had sovereign independence

Answer: D - Issuing authority does not automatically equal full sovereignty.

Must-know facts

- Q9 key D: Ports depended on production, transport and inland consumption.
- Q10 key D: Avoid the one-discoverer myth and preserve accumulated regional knowledge.
- Q11 key D: It is rhetorical evidence, not a quantified balance sheet.
- Q12 key D: Material contact and resident ethnicity are separate claims.
- Q13 key D: Ujjain was a route junction and bead-working centre.
- Q14 key D: Kushanas issued both high-value gold and low-denomination copper.
- Q15 key D: Different transaction scales used different media.
- Q16 key D: Issuing authority does not automatically equal full sovereignty.

UPSC traps

- WRONG: Memorise the option letter.

CORRECT: Revise the evidence distinction and elimination logic.

Mains angle: Use errors to revisit the relevant teaching section.

Study link: Topic 19 learning session.

05. Broad MCQs 17-24

[ANALYSIS] Original questions use strict A -> B -> C -> D rotation. Each solution explains the tested distinction.

Core teaching / solved practice

MCQ 33 - Q17

Which cluster most strongly supports an urban interpretation?

- A. Fortification, planned streets, drains, coins and craft debris together
- B. One imported sherd
- C. One gold coin outside context
- D. One literary mention

Answer: A - Urbanism is inferred from converging indicators.

MCQ 34 - Q18

Taxila's Sirkap is notable for:

- A. Only cave monasteries
- B. Orderly street layout, fortifications and courtyard houses
- C. No evidence of shops
- D. A Chola dockyard

Answer: B - Its morphology shows planned and differentiated urban space.

MCQ 35 - Q19

Which statement about ring wells is correct?

- A. They are always ritual
- B. They occur only in Tamilakam
- C. They are one water/sanitation indicator requiring context
- D. They prove a metropolis

Answer: C - A ring well is useful but not sufficient for urban classification.

MCQ 36 - Q20

Which city should NOT be reduced to a single political-capital function?

- A. Mathura
- B. Ujjain
- C. Taxila
- D. All of these

Answer: D - Each combined route, craft, sacred, market or political roles.

MCQ 37 - Q21

Paithan and Tagara are best placed in:

- A. Inland Deccan commercial networks
- B. The lower Indus delta
- C. Roman Italy
- D. The middle Ganga NBPW core only

Answer: A - They connected Deccan production to western and other routes.

MCQ 38 - Q22

Arikamedu is best described as:

- A. A securely proven Roman colony
- B. An early historic settlement with craft and Mediterranean-linked trade evidence
- C. Only a Buddhist pilgrimage site
- D. A Gupta capital

Answer: B - Settlement chronology and material contact are real; colony language overstates.

MCQ 39 - Q23

Urban-rural interdependence means:

- A. Villages only supplied tax
- B. Towns were self-sufficient
- C. Two-way flows linked food/raw materials with tools, markets and institutions
- D. Cities replaced agriculture

Answer: C - The relationship involved production, demand and redistribution in both directions.

MCQ 40 - Q24

Which claim about commercial mobility is excessive?

- A. Donors gained visibility
- B. Merchants could acquire prestige
- C. Corporate identity could create standing
- D. Commerce abolished hierarchy

Answer: D - Commercial wealth complicated but did not erase social hierarchy.

Must-know facts

- Q17 key D: Urbanism is inferred from converging indicators.
- Q18 key D: Its morphology shows planned and differentiated urban space.
- Q19 key D: A ring well is useful but not sufficient for urban classification.
- Q20 key D: Each combined route, craft, sacred, market or political roles.
- Q21 key D: They connected Deccan production to western and other routes.
- Q22 key D: Settlement chronology and material contact are real; colony language overstates.
- Q23 key D: The relationship involved production, demand and redistribution in both directions.
- Q24 key D: Commercial wealth complicated but did not erase social hierarchy.

UPSC traps

- WRONG: Memorise the option letter.

CORRECT: Revise the evidence distinction and elimination logic.

Mains angle: Use errors to revisit the relevant teaching section.

Study link: Topic 19 learning session.

06. Broad MCQs 25-32

[ANALYSIS] Original questions use strict A -> B -> C -> D rotation. Each solution explains the tested distinction.

Core teaching / solved practice

MCQ 41 - Q25

Buddhist cave donations most directly reveal:

- A. A diverse donor world including merchants and artisans
- B. No economic role for religion
- C. Absence of royal donors
- D. Monastic control of every route

Answer: A - They connect religious patronage with multiple social groups.

MCQ 42 - Q26

Which formulation is safest?

- A. Monks were customs officials
- B. Monasteries were religious institutions embedded in economic landscapes
- C. Buddhism was only a merchant religion
- D. All guilds were Buddhist

Answer: B - Economic embeddedness should not reduce religion to commerce.

MCQ 43 - Q27

The state-commerce relationship is best understood as:

- A. No political role
- B. State ownership of all trade
- C. Enabling, extracting and participating in varying combinations
- D. Uniform free trade

Answer: C - Security, tolls, coinage and infrastructure could help or burden exchange.

MCQ 44 - Q28

Which statement is least defensible?

- A. Tamil rulers levied tolls/customs
- B. Satavahana networks linked interiors and coasts
- C. Kushana power affected route security
- D. Political unity was necessary for all trade

Answer: D - Trade also crossed political boundaries and survived divided sovereignty.

MCQ 45 - Q29

What is the strongest first step in a decline answer?

- A. Separate site-specific decline from wider transformation
- B. Ignore archaeology
- C. Blame Rome alone
- D. Assume all towns vanished in 250 CE

Answer: A - Define the spatial and evidentiary scope before explaining causes.

MCQ 46 - Q30

Which factor should qualify the Roman-trade decline thesis?

- A. Coins never changed
- B. Internal, eastern and regional networks could continue
- C. Ports had no hinterlands
- D. No internal trade existed

Answer: B - A contraction in one circuit need not end all exchange.

MCQ 47 - Q31

A north-Deccan-deep south comparison should emphasise:

- A. Only dynastic lists
- B. One uniform chronology
- C. Different evidence combinations and pathways
- D. No interaction between regions

Answer: C - Comparison requires both regional specificity and interconnection.

MCQ 48 - Q32

A high-scoring verdict should avoid:

- A. Causal linkage
- B. Regional qualification
- C. Named evidence
- D. A single-cause claim that foreign trade created and destroyed all towns

Answer: D - The process was multi-causal and uneven.

Must-know facts

- Q25 key D: They connect religious patronage with multiple social groups.
- Q26 key D: Economic embeddedness should not reduce religion to commerce.
- Q27 key D: Security, tolls, coinage and infrastructure could help or burden exchange.
- Q28 key D: Trade also crossed political boundaries and survived divided sovereignty.
- Q29 key D: Define the spatial and evidentiary scope before explaining causes.
- Q30 key D: A contraction in one circuit need not end all exchange.
- Q31 key D: Comparison requires both regional specificity and interconnection.
- Q32 key D: The process was multi-causal and uneven.

UPSC traps

- WRONG: Memorise the option letter.

CORRECT: Revise the evidence distinction and elimination logic.

Mains angle: Use errors to revisit the relevant teaching section.

Study link: Topic 19 learning session.

07. Remedial MCQs 1-8

[ANALYSIS] Original questions use strict A -> B -> C -> D rotation. Each solution explains the tested distinction.

Core teaching / solved practice

MCQ 49 - Q1

Roman coins at a site prove first and foremost:

- A. Contact, bullion flow or circulation in context
- B. Roman sovereignty
- C. A Roman colony
- D. Latin-speaking majority

Answer: A - Start with the narrowest evidence-safe inference.

MCQ 50 - Q2

A guild deposit proves:

- A. Royal ownership
- B. Entrusted corporate endowment activity
- C. Uniform interest law
- D. Modern deposit insurance

Answer: B - The record supports custody/income provision, not a modern system.

MCQ 51 - Q3

Uttarapatha should be treated as:

- A. A coastal shipping lane
- B. A Gupta-only term
- C. A broad and changing northern corridor/network
- D. One surviving paved road

Answer: C - Do not turn a route concept into one immutable line.

MCQ 52 - Q4

One coin hoard cannot by itself establish:

- A. A chronological clue
- B. Coin presence
- C. Metal composition
- D. Total regional prosperity

Answer: D - Prosperity needs settlement and production evidence too.

MCQ 53 - Q5

The safest description of Pattanam is:

- A. A strong but debated Muziris identification
- B. Gupta capital
- C. Inland Kushana mint
- D. Secure Roman colony

Answer: A - Keep the identification debate visible.

MCQ 54 - Q6

Araghatta belongs in this package mainly as:

- A. Proof of Roman technology
- B. An adjacent routed PYQ with chronology caution
- C. A coin type
- D. A guild office

Answer: B - It is included because the local ledger routes it here.

MCQ 55 - Q7

Hundi should be described as:

- A. A c. 200 BCE coin
- B. A Roman amphora
- C. A post-Harsha credit/bill-of-exchange concept, not back-projected
- D. A Satavahana tax

Answer: C - Respect the later chronological owner.

MCQ 56 - Q8

The best decline conclusion is:

- A. Rome alone caused collapse
- B. All cities vanished
- C. Trade ended permanently
- D. Urban systems transformed unevenly across regions

Answer: D - Use decline only where site evidence supports it.

Must-know facts

- Q1 key D: Start with the narrowest evidence-safe inference.
- Q2 key D: The record supports custody/income provision, not a modern system.
- Q3 key D: Do not turn a route concept into one immutable line.
- Q4 key D: Prosperity needs settlement and production evidence too.
- Q5 key D: Keep the identification debate visible.
- Q6 key D: It is included because the local ledger routes it here.
- Q7 key D: Respect the later chronological owner.
- Q8 key D: Use decline only where site evidence supports it.

UPSC traps

- WRONG: Memorise the option letter.

CORRECT: Revise the evidence distinction and elimination logic.

Mains angle: Use errors to revisit the relevant teaching section.

Study link: Topic 19 learning session.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

23. Verified PYQ audit and direct/adjacent ownership

[FACT] No directly owned UPSC Mains PYQ was found in the locally audited routing ledgers. Four routed Prelims demands are included; three are adjacent in chronology or technology.

Core teaching / solved practice

- UPSC Prelims 2020 Q25 - adjacent chronological owner: Which phrase defines the nature of the 'Hundi' generally referred to in sources of the post-Harsha period? Options included an advisory, a daily-account diary, a bill of exchange, and a feudal order. Answer: bill of exchange (option C in the locally held paper). [FACT] A hundi was a credit/remittance instrument, not a coin. [LIMIT] This PYQ concerns the post-Harsha period and is included only because the local routing ledger assigns it to Topic 19; it must not be back-projected as a fully developed instrument in c. 200 BCE-250 CE. Status: INFERRED FROM AUTHORITATIVE SUBJECT KNOWLEDGE - official 2020 key not held locally.
- UPSC Prelims 2020 Q82 - adjacent Gupta-period owner: With reference to the Gupta period, Ghantasala, Kadura and Chaul were known as what? Options included ports handling foreign trade, capitals, stone-art centres and Buddhist pilgrimage centres. Answer: ports handling foreign trade (option A in the locally held paper). [ANALYSIS] The question tests continuity and relocation of maritime nodes beyond Topic 19's core window. [LIMIT] It is not evidence that every named port peaked before 250 CE. Status: INFERRED FROM AUTHORITATIVE SUBJECT KNOWLEDGE - official 2020 key not held locally.
- UPSC Prelims 2025 Q13 - adjacent technology route: The irrigation device called Araghatta was: leather bag over a pulley; large wheel with earthen pots tied to the outer ends of its spokes; large earthen pot driven by bullocks; or hand-pulled bucket. Answer: a large wheel with earthen pots tied to the outer ends of its spokes (option B; official Set-A key is held locally). [LIMIT] The local canonical file places the term cautiously and notes that its exact earliest attestation is debated; it is not a core craft-commerce institution of 200 BCE-250 CE. Status: OFFICIALLY KEYED LOCALLY.
- UPSC Prelims 2026 routed question - direct money-economy demand: Pali texts contain definite coin references such as kahapana, nikkha, kamsa and kakanika; archaeological punch-marked coins, mostly silver, corroborate the literary evidence. With which developments are these statements associated: emergence of urban life and/or transition to money economy? Answer: both emergence of urban life and transition to money economy (option C in the locally held provisional Set-A material). The textual-archaeological pairing is the key: terminology alone is not enough, and punch-marked finds alone do not reveal every monetary practice. Status: PROVISIONAL 2026 KEY - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED.

Must-know facts

- Direct: 2026 Pali coin/money-economy demand.
- Adjacent: 2020 Hundi, 2020 Gupta ports, 2025 Araghatta.

UPSC traps

- WRONG: Treat every routed question as core-window evidence.

CORRECT: Label actual owner and chronology explicitly.

Mains angle: Do not invent a direct Mains PYQ; use originals for answer writing.

Study link: Local Prelims routing ledgers 2018-2026.

26. Solved Mains practice - 10, 15 and 20 marks

[ANALYSIS] Each answer follows claim - named evidence - significance - limitation and ends with 'Why this earns marks'.

Core teaching / solved practice

- 10 marks / 150 words - Explain how agrarian surplus and craft specialisation reinforced early historic urban growth. Model solution: [ANALYSIS] Early historic towns were concentrations of non-food-producing groups, so urban growth required a productive countryside and mechanisms for converting surplus into specialised output. First, diversified agriculture supplied food and raw materials. [FACT] Sanghol's early-centuries-CE plant record includes cereals, pulses, oilseeds, cotton, spices and a dye plant; Deccan evidence supports cotton and paddy expansion. This sustained consumers and fed textile and dyeing chains. Second, specialisation multiplied value. [FACT] Ujjain's agate-carnelian working, Arikamedu/Uraiyur dyeing vats and Telangana iron artefacts show regionally distinct production. Third, towns and routes concentrated demand, exchange and skills, while moulds and repeated forms suggest batch production. [LIMIT] Surplus did not automatically create cities: political security, transport, institutions and market demand remained necessary, and site evidence is uneven. Thus agrarian production and craft specialisation formed a reciprocal rather than one-way urban system.

Why this earns marks: It gives a direct causal thesis, four named evidence units, explains significance and ends with a qualification.

- 15 marks / 250 words - Examine the relationship between internal trade routes and overseas exchange in c. 200 BCE-250 CE. Model solution: [ANALYSIS] Overseas exchange was the seaward extension of inland production and redistribution, not an autonomous 'Roman trade' enclave. [FACT] The Taxila-Mathura-Ujjain-Bharuch corridor linked the north-west and Malwa to a western port; Ujjain also received the Kaushambi route and worked agate-carnelian beads. [FACT] Deccan nodes such as Paithan and Tagara channelled agrarian and craft goods towards western and southern outlets. Sangam chattu caravans carried paddy, salt and pepper, showing inland movement behind coastal trade. At ports, [FACT] Bharuch, Muziris, Arikamedu, Puhar and Tamralipti aggregated goods, collected customs, enabled shipping and redistributed imports. Mediterranean-linked exchange moved pepper, textiles, beads, pearls, stones, ivory and iron/steel outward, while coins/bullion, amphorae, ceramics, glass and metals came inward. [ANALYSIS] Ports therefore depended on hinterland routes, while overseas demand could deepen selected craft specialisation and urban consumption. State security under Kushana and Satavahana polities and local toll/custom arrangements affected transaction costs. [LIMIT] Route maps are reconstructions, not fixed highways; imported ceramics do not prove foreign colonies; and luxury trade did not replace internal or subsistence exchange. The relationship was nested: village and craft cluster to market node, route junction, port and multi-nodal Indian Ocean circuit.

Why this earns marks: It answers relationship rather than listing routes, uses six named nodes and goods, and qualifies maps, colony claims and trade composition.

- 20 marks / 250 words - 'Crafts, commerce and urban growth formed a mutually reinforcing system in post-Mauryan India.' Critically discuss. Model solution: [ANALYSIS] The proposition is persuasive if treated as a networked, regionally uneven process rooted in an older agrarian-urban base. Production came first but was not isolated. [FACT] Sanghol's diversified crop record and Deccan cotton/paddy evidence supplied food and fibre; Ujjain bead working, Telangana iron, Arikamedu/Uraiyur dyeing vats, ivory, glass, pottery and coin moulds show specialised manufacture. Commerce connected these clusters. [FACT] Taxila-Mathura-Ujjain-Bharuch and Kaushambi-Ujjain corridors, Paithan-Tagara routes and Sangam caravans linked hinterlands to ports. Institutions reduced continuity and trust problems: [FACT] potter, oil-miller, weaver and flour-maker bodies received deposits for recurring religious provision; merchant and artisan donors appear at western Deccan caves. Coinage widened transaction options through Kushana gold/copper, Satavahana multi-metal issues, civic coins and Roman-linked bullion. Urban nodes concentrated consumers, workshops, rulers and religious establishments. [FACT] Sirkap's streets, fortifications, courtyard houses and possible shops, and Hastinapura's bricks, ring well, tools, beads and coins illustrate functional concentration. The loop was reinforcing: urban demand deepened crafts, commerce expanded markets, and surplus sustained non-producers.

[LIMIT] It was not automatic or uniform. Guild evidence is local, monetisation incomplete, imported ceramics do not prove colonies, and foreign luxury trade cannot explain every town. From the third century, some regions contracted while others transformed, reflecting political and route change as well as overseas demand. The system therefore

explains a major early-historic florescence, but only through regional comparison and source triangulation. Why this earns marks: It integrates production, institutions, routes, coins, morphology and decline with more than eight named evidence units and sustained qualification.

Must-know facts

- 10M: 2-3 precise examples.
- 15M: 4-6 examples.
- 20M: 5-8 or more integrated evidence units.

UPSC traps

- WRONG: List sites without inference.

CORRECT: Explain what each named site or record proves and its limit.

Mains angle: Practise thesis, thematic body, counterpoint and graded verdict.

Study link: Answer spine.

02. Solved verified/routed Prelims PYQs

[FACT] Wording is taken from the locally held papers or their audited neutral rendering; ownership is labelled.

Core teaching / solved practice

- UPSC Prelims 2020 Q25 - adjacent chronological owner. Question: Which phrase defines the nature of the 'Hundi' generally referred to in sources of the post-Harsha period? Options included an advisory, a daily-account diary, a bill of exchange, and a feudal order. Solution: Answer: bill of exchange (option C in the locally held paper). [FACT] A hundi was a credit/remittance instrument, not a coin. [LIMIT] This PYQ concerns the post-Harsha period and is included only because the local routing ledger assigns it to Topic 19; it must not be back-projected as a fully developed instrument in c. 200 BCE-250 CE. Key status: INFERRED FROM AUTHORITATIVE SUBJECT KNOWLEDGE - official 2020 key not held locally.
- UPSC Prelims 2020 Q82 - adjacent Gupta-period owner. Question: With reference to the Gupta period, Ghantasala, Kadura and Chaul were known as what? Options included ports handling foreign trade, capitals, stone-art centres and Buddhist pilgrimage centres. Solution: Answer: ports handling foreign trade (option A in the locally held paper). [ANALYSIS] The question tests continuity and relocation of maritime nodes beyond Topic 19's core window. [LIMIT] It is not evidence that every named port peaked before 250 CE. Key status: INFERRED FROM AUTHORITATIVE SUBJECT KNOWLEDGE - official 2020 key not held locally.
- UPSC Prelims 2025 Q13 - adjacent technology route. Question: The irrigation device called Araghatta was: leather bag over a pulley; large wheel with earthen pots tied to the outer ends of its spokes; large earthen pot driven by bullocks; or hand-pulled bucket. Solution: Answer: a large wheel with earthen pots tied to the outer ends of its spokes (option B; official Set-A key is held locally). [LIMIT] The local canonical file places the term cautiously and notes that its exact earliest attestation is debated; it is not a core craft-commerce institution of 200 BCE-250 CE. Key status: OFFICIALLY KEYED LOCALLY.
- UPSC Prelims 2026 routed question - direct money-economy demand. Question: Pali texts contain definite coin references such as kahapana, nikkha, kamsa and kakanika; archaeological punch-marked coins, mostly silver, corroborate the literary evidence. With which developments are these statements associated: emergence of urban life and/or transition to money economy? Solution: Answer: both emergence of urban life and transition to money economy (option C in the locally held provisional Set-A material). The textual-archaeological pairing is the key: terminology alone is not enough, and punch-marked finds alone do not reveal every monetary practice. Key status: PROVISIONAL 2026 KEY - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED.

Must-know facts

- Hundi = bill of exchange.
- Ghantasala/Kadura/Chaul = foreign-trade ports.
- Araghatta = wheel with earthen pots.
- Pali evidence supports urban and money transitions.

UPSC traps

- WRONG: Back-project later Hundi evidence.

CORRECT: Keep it post-Harsha.

Mains angle: Convert objective distinctions into source-aware notes.

Study link: PYQ ledgers.

08. Solved 10-mark questions

[ANALYSIS] Two 150-word models with compact evidence density.

Core teaching / solved practice

- 10 marks / 150 words - Explain how agrarian surplus and craft specialisation reinforced early historic urban growth. Model solution: [ANALYSIS] Early historic towns were concentrations of non-food-producing groups, so urban growth required a productive countryside and mechanisms for converting surplus into specialised output. First, diversified agriculture supplied food and raw materials. [FACT] Sanghol's early-centuries-CE plant record includes cereals, pulses, oilseeds, cotton, spices and a dye plant; Deccan evidence supports cotton and paddy expansion. This sustained consumers and fed textile and dyeing chains. Second, specialisation multiplied value. [FACT] Ujjain's agate-carnelian working, Arikamedu/Uraiyur dyeing vats and Telangana iron artefacts show regionally distinct production. Third, towns and routes concentrated demand, exchange and skills, while moulds and repeated forms suggest batch production. [LIMIT] Surplus did not automatically create cities: political security, transport, institutions and market demand remained necessary, and site evidence is uneven. Thus agrarian production and craft specialisation formed a reciprocal rather than one-way urban system.

Why this earns marks: It gives a direct causal thesis, four named evidence units, explains significance and ends with a qualification.

- 10 marks / 150 words - Distinguish evidence for guild corporate identity from claims about modern banking. Model solution: [ANALYSIS] Shrenis were occupational corporate bodies, but equating them with modern banks overstates the evidence. [FACT] The Ahichchhatra kumhakra seniya seal records a potters' guild; another sealing may refer to arrowhead/spearhead makers. These establish corporate identity. [FACT] Second-century-CE Maharashtra records entrusted money with potter, oil-miller and weaver guilds to provide monastic necessities, while a Mathura flour-makers' deposit funded recurring Brahmana service. These show reputation, custody and income-bearing endowment functions. [ANALYSIS] Such arrangements reduced continuity risk by attaching obligations to a body rather than an individual. [LIMIT] The records do not establish universal deposits, regulated reserves, negotiable instruments, deposit insurance or uniform interest rates. Nigama coins similarly indicate limited merchant authority, not sovereignty. Therefore 'financial intermediary' or 'endowment custodian' is safer than 'bank'.

Why this earns marks: It distinguishes concepts, names three records, explains institutional significance and explicitly controls analogy.

Must-know facts

- Direct thesis; 2-3 precise examples; one explicit limit.

UPSC traps

- WRONG: Use a 20-mark structure for 10 marks.

CORRECT: Prioritise the causal core and concise qualification.

Mains angle: Rewrite each in 7 minutes.

Study link: Production and guild sections.

09. Solved 15-mark questions

[ANALYSIS] Two 250-word models requiring relationship and critical assessment.

Core teaching / solved practice

- 15 marks / 250 words - Examine the relationship between internal trade routes and overseas exchange in c. 200 BCE-250 CE. Model solution: [ANALYSIS] Overseas exchange was the seaward extension of inland production and redistribution, not an autonomous 'Roman trade' enclave. [FACT] The Taxila-Mathura-Ujjain-Bharuch corridor linked the north-west and Malwa to a western port; Ujjain also received the Kaushambi route and worked agate-carnelian beads. [FACT] Deccan nodes such as Paithan and Tagara channelled agrarian and craft goods towards western and southern outlets. Sangam chattu caravans carried paddy, salt and pepper, showing inland movement behind coastal trade. At ports, [FACT] Bharuch, Muziris, Arikamedu, Puhar and Tamralipti aggregated goods, collected customs, enabled shipping and redistributed imports. Mediterranean-linked exchange moved pepper, textiles, beads, pearls, stones, ivory and iron/steel outward, while coins/bullion, amphorae, ceramics, glass and metals came inward. [ANALYSIS] Ports therefore depended on hinterland routes, while overseas demand could deepen selected craft specialisation and urban consumption. State security under Kushana and Satavahana polities and local toll/custom arrangements affected transaction costs. [LIMIT] Route maps are reconstructions, not fixed highways; imported ceramics do not prove foreign colonies; and luxury trade did not replace internal or subsistence exchange. The relationship was nested: village and craft cluster to market node, route junction, port and multi-nodal Indian Ocean circuit.

Why this earns marks: It answers relationship rather than listing routes, uses six named nodes and goods, and qualifies maps, colony claims and trade composition.

- 15 marks / 250 words - Critically assess coinage as evidence for monetisation and prosperity. Model solution: [ANALYSIS] Coinage is indispensable evidence for authority, exchange and connectivity, but it is not a self-sufficient index of prosperity. [FACT] Indo-Greek bilingual and bi-script issues illuminate rulers otherwise poorly known; Kushanas issued gold and abundant copper; Satavahanas used silver, copper, lead and potin; Tamil dynastic issues and Roman-linked coins widened the peninsular record. [FACT] City coins from Ujjayini, Kaushambi, Vidisha, Varanasi and Taxila and a few negama issues reveal civic and corporate authority. Coin moulds at sites such as Sunet demonstrate minting activity, while Pali terms such as kahapana and kakanika are corroborated by punch-marked silver finds. These data show multiple denominations, issuers and transaction spheres. Yet [LIMIT] hoards may represent savings, crisis concealment or bullion rather than routine market use; gold was unsuitable for most small transactions; coin survival is shaped by metal and excavation; and barter, kind payments and customary obligations continued. Roman coins may have circulated, been valued as bullion, imitated or counter-struck, so their exact use needs context. [ANALYSIS] Prosperity should therefore be tested through coinage plus settlement expansion, craft debris, inscriptions, route evidence and consumption patterns. Coinage demonstrates monetisation's reach and political symbolism, not a universal cash economy or ancient GDP.

Why this earns marks: It balances six coin classes with four methodological limits and provides a clear corroboration protocol.

Must-know facts

- Use 4-6 examples and a clear counterpoint.

UPSC traps

- WRONG: Route list without relationship.

CORRECT: Show how inland, port and overseas levels connect.

Mains angle: Rewrite each in 11 minutes.

Study link: Routes and coinage sections.

10. Solved 20-mark questions

[ANALYSIS] Two synthesis models integrate the whole topic and regional comparison.

Core teaching / solved practice

- 20 marks / 250 words - 'Crafts, commerce and urban growth formed a mutually reinforcing system in post-Mauryan India.' Critically discuss. Model solution: [ANALYSIS] The proposition is persuasive if treated as a networked, regionally uneven process rooted in an older agrarian-urban base. Production came first but was not isolated. [FACT] Sanghol's diversified crop record and Deccan cotton/paddy evidence supplied food and fibre; Ujjain bead working, Telangana iron, Arikamedu/Uraiyur dyeing vats, ivory, glass, pottery and coin moulds show specialised manufacture. Commerce connected these clusters. [FACT] Taxila-Mathura-Ujjain-Bharuch and Kaushambi-Ujjain corridors, Paithan-Tagara routes and Sangam caravans linked hinterlands to ports. Institutions reduced continuity and trust problems: [FACT] potter, oil-miller, weaver and flour-maker bodies received deposits for recurring religious provision; merchant and artisan donors appear at western Deccan caves. Coinage widened transaction options through Kushana gold/copper, Satavahana multi-metal issues, civic coins and Roman-linked bullion. Urban nodes concentrated consumers, workshops, rulers and religious establishments. [FACT] Sirkap's streets, fortifications, courtyard houses and possible shops, and Hastinapura's bricks, ring well, tools, beads and coins illustrate functional concentration. The loop was reinforcing: urban demand deepened crafts, commerce expanded markets, and surplus sustained non-producers.

[LIMIT] It was not automatic or uniform. Guild evidence is local, monetisation incomplete, imported ceramics do not prove colonies, and foreign luxury trade cannot explain every town. From the third century, some regions contracted while others transformed, reflecting political and route change as well as overseas demand. The system therefore explains a major early-historic florescence, but only through regional comparison and source triangulation. Why this earns marks: It integrates production, institutions, routes, coins, morphology and decline with more than eight named evidence units and sustained qualification.

- 20 marks / 250 words - Compare the urban-commercial trajectories of north India, the Deccan and the deep south in c. 200 BCE-250 CE. Model solution: [ANALYSIS] The three zones participated in interconnected early-historic growth, but their starting points, evidence and political forms differed. North India built on the second-urbanisation legacy of NBPW, punch-marked coins and Ganga towns. [FACT] Taxila's successive cities, Mathura's route-religious-craft role, Ujjain's bead industry and junction position, and burnt-brick/ring-well levels at Hastinapura show established urban continuity intensified under Indo-Greek, Shaka and Kushana contexts. The Deccan combined agrarian expansion with inland-coastal routes and religious patronage. [FACT] Satavahana multi-metal coinage, Paithan and Tagara, western Deccan cave donors, guild deposits in Maharashtra and lower-Krishna centres such as Amaravati reveal a network polity and commercial landscape. The deep south grew from megalithic and chiefly backgrounds into literate port-centred systems. [FACT] Tamil-Brahmi at craft and Red Sea-linked sites, dynastic coins, Sangam caravans, Uraiyur dyeing, Arikamedu craft/import evidence and Muziris/Puhar traditions show production and maritime integration.

[ANALYSIS] North India's route cities were more closely tied to older urban sequences; Deccan growth joined plateau interiors to two coasts; deep-south centres reveal strong port and literary visibility alongside emerging state structures.

[LIMIT] These are tendencies, not sealed regions: routes and commodities crossed them, excavation is unequal, Sangam texts were later compiled, Pattanam-Muziris remains debated and dynastic archaeological labels can mislead. Thus comparison should recognise shared drivers - surplus, crafts, routes, institutions and coinage - while preserving distinct regional chronologies and evidence profiles. Why this earns marks: It uses a consistent comparative framework, gives named evidence in all three regions and avoids both uniformity and isolation.

Must-know facts

- Use 5-8+ evidence units and a graded verdict.

UPSC traps

- WRONG: Foreign trade monocause.

CORRECT: Integrate production, institutions, circulation and regional limits.

Mains angle: Rewrite each in 14 minutes.

Study link: Historiography and answer architecture.

FINAL CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES - PLACED LAST

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on “26. Solved Mains practice - 10, 15 and 20 marks”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The model answer or solved analysis above is the executable content base; retain its named evidence, causal links and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic summary.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 20-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise six to eight named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “26. Solved Mains practice - 10, 15 and 20 marks”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.